🗽 Immigration & Cities: Reading

US History · Unit 3 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with push/pull notes, Ellis Island, Voices of Angel Island, How the Other Half Lives

Name: _____

Coming to America, 1880-1920

Between 1880 and 1920 about 20 million immigrants came to the United States. People were pushed out of their home countries by war, hunger, poverty and persecution. They were pulled to America by factory and railroad jobs, cheap land and the promise of freedom. Most came from Europe, at first from northern and western countries such as Ireland and Germany and later from southern and eastern countries such as Italy, Poland and Russia.

Most European immigrants arrived in New York Harbor. They passed the Statue of Liberty, dedicated in 1886, with Emma Lazarus's poem welcoming “your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to breathe free.” At Ellis Island, doctors gave quick medical exams and checked eyes for trachoma, and inspectors checked legal papers. About 2 percent were sent back.

On the West Coast the story was different. The Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 was the first US law to ban immigration by one ethnic group. At Angel Island in San Francisco Bay, opened in 1910, Chinese immigrants were held for weeks or even months and questioned closely. Some carved poems about their sadness and anger into the walls.

Most new immigrants settled in cities, where the jobs were. In New York's Lower East Side, families crowded into tenements: narrow buildings with dark rooms, little air and shared toilets. Disease and fire were constant dangers. Reporter Jacob Riis photographed these conditions in his 1890 book “How the Other Half Lives,” which pushed New York to pass housing laws.

Immigrants built railroads, worked in factories and opened shops and newspapers. Many Americans welcomed them, but others feared job competition and different religions and languages. Cartoons of the time often drew immigrants with cruel stereotypes. People argued about whether America should be a “melting pot” where cultures blend, or a place where each group keeps its own traditions.

Check your reading

1. Give two push factors and two pull factors.

2. How was Angel Island different from Ellis Island?

3. Why did Jacob Riis take photographs of tenements?